

Rockhopper penguin

Eudyptes chrysocome

After six months at sea, chasing shrimplike krill and fish, rockhopper penguins must begin nesting promptly once melting sea ice allows them access to firm land. Of around 3.5 million pairs, some 2.5 million breed in the Falkland Islands. Males return first, to begin building nests of stones, grass, and fish bones. Courtship is short, but caressing, billing, and other rituals reaffirm past pair-bonds and establish new ones—vital if pairs are to act in concert to rear their chick.

Each parent incubates two eggs while the other is away feeding at sea for 7–17 days. They may forage up to 155 miles (250 km) from the colony. With such long periods between meals, only the stronger chick survives. Unusually among birds, the second egg,

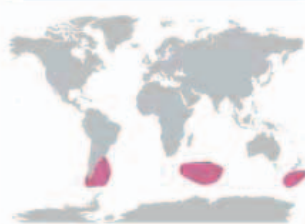
laid several days after the first, can be 70 percent heavier and hatches first. Scientists speculate whether the species is still evolving a single-egg clutch. The chick is brooded constantly for three weeks before being moved into a nursery, where “aunties” strive to protect vast numbers of chicks from giant petrels, skuas, and gulls. Only the parents feed their chick, and the first few days between parental guarding and establishment in the nursery expose it to the greatest risk of predation.

strong webbed feet
with sharp claws
give good grip



distinctive black
and yellow crest and
yellow eyebrow

- ↔ 20 in (51 cm)
- ⚖ 6 lb (2.7 kg)
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🐟 Fish, crabs, squid
- 🏠 



S. South America;
S. Pacific, S. Atlantic,
S. Indian, Southern Oceans

▷ HURRYING HOME

Having escaped predatory leopard seals lurking inshore, these rockhoppers are heading back to the colony with a belly full of fish.

